

Eritrea



The newest nation in Africa only emerged as an independent republic in 1993.

1885 Italy occupies Massawa and begins colonization of Eritrea. In the centuries before this Eritrea successively passed under the control of Arabs, Ottomans, and Egyptians.

1895 Italy launches an attempted invasion of Ethiopia from Eritrea.

1896 Italian forces are defeated at the battle of Adowa.

1936 Eritrea becomes part of large Italian empire in East Africa after Italy successfully invades, conquers Ethiopia, and merges it with Italian Somaliland.

1941 The administration of Eritrea is taken over by the UK after the defeat of Italian forces in East Africa during World War II. The new administration permits political activity.

1950 The UN General Assembly gives Eritrea self-government within a federal union with Ethiopia, which rejects it.

1952 Eritrea absorbed by Ethiopia.

1961 Beginning of armed struggle against Ethiopian rule by the Eritrean People's Liberation Front (EPLF).

1991 EPLF takes Asmara, the capital, and helps overthrow the military government in Ethiopia.

1993 Formal independence.

1998 Border war with Ethiopia over a small area of disputed territory around the towns of Badme and Sheraro; over 70,000 troops are killed on both sides.

2000 OAU peace treaty is signed.

2001 Ethiopia completes troop withdrawal from Eritrea; a buffer zone is created to separate the two armies.

2001 The two countries agree to abide by the decision of an international boundary commission.

2003 Boundary commission awards Badme to Eritrea; Ethiopia refuses to accept the decision it has signed.

2005 Eritrea expels UN observers.

2006 UN accuses Eritrea of arming the rival Islamist administration in neighboring Somalia.

2007 Eritrea accepts the findings of an independent boundary commission on its disputed border with Ethiopia.

2009 Fighting breaks out between Eritrean and Djiboutian forces at disputed Ras Doumeira border.

Djibouti



Little more than a port with a desert hinterland, Djibouti has historically depended on shipping.

1862 France gains control of the trading port of Obock in northern Djibouti.

1897 In a treaty signed between the emperor of Ethiopia and France, Djibouti is designated "the official outlet for Ethiopian commerce."

1909–17 The Franco–Ethiopian Railway Company (CFE) builds a railway from Djibouti to Addis Ababa.

1977 Independence from France.

1981–92 One-party state.

1991 Front for the Restoration of Unity and Democracy (FRUD), an Afar guerrilla group, launches armed insurrection.

1994 Peace agreement with FRUD.

2000 Civil war ends.

2002 US sets up a base in support of its war on terror.

2002 President Ismail Guelleh wins reelection as sole candidate.

2003 Multi-party elections held.

2006 A UN report accuses Djibouti of arming Islamist rebels in Somalia.

2009 Outbreak of fighting at disputed border with Eritrea.

Ethiopia



The only African state to avoid colonization, Ethiopia was the cradle of an ancient civilization.

500 BCE Foundation of kingdom of Axum, the nucleus of later Ethiopia.

328 CE Christianity adopted as state religion of Axum.

1270 Overthrow of Zagwe dynasty by Amhara princes. Foundation of Solomonid dynasty.

1528–43 Muslim invasion led by Ahmad Gran eventually repelled with Portuguese assistance.

1855 Amhara chief overthrows puppet emperor at Gondar and proclaims himself Emperor Tewodoros (Theodore) II. In 1868 he commits suicide rather than surrender to British expeditionary force.

1889 Menelik II becomes emperor and begins imperial expansion east and south.

1896 Italian invasion defeated at Adowa.

1913 Menelik II dies. In 1916 his son, Lij Iyasu, is deposed for converting to Islam and proposing alliance with Turkey. Menelik's daughter, Zauditu, becomes empress with Ras Tafari as regent.

1930 Zauditu dies. Ras Tafari Makonnen crowned Emperor Haile Selassie.

1936 Italians occupy Ethiopia. League of Nations fails to react.

1941 British oust Italians and restore Haile Selassie.

1952 Eritrea is federated with Ethiopia.

1963 Organization of African Unity is fomed with headquarters in Addis Ababa.

1972–74 Famine kills 200,000.

1974 Strikes and army mutinies against Haile Selassie's autocratic rule. Derg (Military Committee) stages coup.

1975 Ethiopia becomes socialist state, with nationalizations, worker cooperatives, and health reforms.

1977 Colonel Mengistu Haile Mariam takes over. Somali invasion of Ogaden defeated with Soviet and Cuban help.

1978–79 Thousands of political opponents killed or imprisoned.

1984 One million people die in famine after drought and years of war. Live Aid concert raises funds for relief. Drought returns in 1987.

1988 Eritrean and Tigrean People's Liberation Fronts (EPLF and TPLF) begin new offensives. Mengistu's budget is for "Everything to the War Front."

1989 Military coup fails. TPLF in control of most of Tigre. TPLF and Ethiopian People's Revolutionary Movement form alliance—EPRDF.

1991 Mengistu accepts defeat and flees country. EPRDF enters Addis Ababa, sets up provisional government.

1993 Transitional rule ends. EPRDF wins landslide in multi-party elections and sets up first democratic government. New

nine-state federation is formed as Eritrea gains its independence.

1998–2000 Tensions with Eritrea escalate into a border war.

2001 Ethiopia withdraws troops from Eritrea, but refuses to accept boundary commission's award to Eritrea in 2003.

2006 Ethiopia sends troops to help overthrow Islamic forces in Somalia.

2007 Ethiopia rejects findings of international border commission on disputed border with Eritrea.

2009 Ethiopia withdraws its troops from Somalia.

2010 Menes Zelewi reelected president for fourth term amid allegations of fraud.

« 182–83 South of the Sahara

Somalia



An ethnically homogenous, poor state in the Horn of Africa torn apart by clan warfare.

1884, 1889 The lands of the Somalis become British and Italian colonies.

1960 Unification at independence.

1964–87 Conflict with Ethiopia over Ogaden region.

1969 Siad Barre is dictator.

1991 Siad Barre ousted. Civil war and clan chaos result in mass starvation. In the north, Somaliland declares secession.

1993 US rangers are killed when Somali militias shoot down two US Black Hawk helicopters in Mogadishu.

1995 UN withdraws as international community abandons country.

2001 Transitional national government established. It governs from Djibouti (and later Kenya) as it is unable to control Mogadishu.

ETHIOPIAN EMPEROR (1892–1975)

HAILE SELASSIE I

Haile Selassie I was the emperor of Ethiopia (1930–74), a throne supposedly descended from King Solomon. When Italy invaded Ethiopia in 1935, he led his troops in the field, but in 1936 was forced to flee and twice appealed in vain to the League of Nations for action against Italy. In 1940, Haile Selassie returned to Africa with British aid, and in 1941 regained his throne. In the 1960s and 1970s he worked for pan-African aims, particularly through the Organization of African Unity, but in 1974 the army seized control and arrested him. He was killed in prison on the orders of the coup leaders in 1975.

